such locations will have needed a lot of persuading to abstain from eating meat and organizing sacrificial ritual. From the abundance of bones in early historic sites spread over both North and South India, there is little doubt that animal flesh was in great demand,[26] with people of means probably also importing exotic livestock. The earliest of these, the Harappans of the third millennium BCE, relished catfish brought in from a coastal location several hundred kilometres distant. There is no reason to believe that the well to do two thousand years later did not crave similar delicacies.

In the Karnataka–Andhra belt, death rituals as evident from megaliths included animal parts in the burials alongside the human dead. Similarly, in ancient Hindu belief and practice, sacrifices of goats, oxen, rams, and horses commonly figure in offerings to the gods. The merit so obtained, one commentator points out, is extolled in the *Mahabharata*: 'animals killed in sacrifices to the accompaniment of Vedic mantras went to heaven and it [the epic] narrates the story of king Rantideva in whose sacrifices two thousand animals and cows were killed every day.'[27] Some scriptures frowned on or had misgivings about these. In the *Satapatha Brahmana* the eater of meat is said to be eaten in his next birth by the animal killed.[28] Regardless of these occasional scriptural impediments, the general picture is one of a populace not just carnivorous but eagerly so.

Ashoka could scarcely have been unaware that his dictum would spur resentment. This is possibly why the edict presents the proscription alongside an outline of altered culinary palace practice:

> Many hundred thousands of living beings were formerly slaughtered every day in the kitchen of king Priyadarshin, Beloved of the Gods, for the sake of curry.
>
> But now, when this record relating to Dharma is written, only three living creatures are killed (daily) for the sake of curry, two birds and one animal.
>
> Even this animal is not (slaughtered) regularly.
>
> These three living beings too shall not be killed in future.[29]